

HOW WE GET FREE

BLACK FEMINISM AND THE COMBAHEE RIVER COLLECTIVE

Edited and Introduced
by Keeanga-Yamahtta Taylor



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COMMENTS BY BARBARA RANSBY

at Socialism 2017 Conference Panel

Fortieth Anniversary of the Combahee River Collective Statement

I was not in the Combahee River Collective, but I was inspired by the Combahee River Collective. As a historian, I want to preface my remarks with a few critical comments and observations. One is that sometimes we talk about these empowering, important historical moments, and we are looking for blueprints or road maps. Unfortunately, history does not offer us that. We have our own work to do, in our own time. Nevertheless, looking at the Combahee River Collective statement and praxis does situate us in a certain trajectory of history that many writers on the left have ignored. It foregrounds and centers the organizing and intellectual work of radical Black feminists who were also lesbians. So it is important to mark that fact.

The other thing I want to do is to pay tribute to the founders of the Combahee River Collective (CRC). They would be the first to tell you that we also cannot romanticize those moments. CRC founders have talked about the good times, but within every struggle that we look back upon with rose-colored glasses, there was another layer of struggle, right? There were the struggles within the struggle. And they persevered. So I think those are important lessons and caveats. The third thing is something that Barbara Smith has alluded to, which is that there is a kind of artificial way that we try to tame the timelines of the past. We put them in brackets of periods and so forth. Historians are trained to do that. But, in fact, the Combahee River Collective was embedded in a specific period of struggle defined by a number of significant events and thrusts. For example, 2017 is also the fiftieth anniversary of the 1967 Detroit rebellion, which had a powerful impact on my own political consciousness. I grew up in Detroit. I was ten years old in 1967 when the rebellion occurred. And I see the CRC's work and the explosion of protest in the summer of 1967 as very much related. Black feminism didn't grow on another planet and then drop down on this one. In fact it was a product of, and influenced by, the larger

movements of its time. And in fact, I would say it is the umbrella under which we have to see that larger Black political past, beginning in the early 1960s.

Barbara Smith and Demita Frazier have laid out some of the background and the history of CRC. But I want to say, too, that the Combahee River Collective Statement, as well as the example of the Combahee River Collective, laid the ground for a number of projects that came after that. African American Women in Defense of Ourselves (AAWIDO) was a project I was very involved in, in 1991. It was an effort by Black feminists to respond to the nomination of sexist and conservative Clarence Thomas to the US Supreme Court. We argued that Thomas's use of the language of race—he charged his critics with engaging in a “high tech lynching”—was actually a perversion of the struggle against racism and white supremacy, and the public discourse ignored the complex reality of Black women's lived experiences. As people will recall, Thomas's appointment to the court was almost derailed by credible allegations of sexual harassment by a Black woman attorney and legal scholar, Anita Hill, who previously worked for Thomas. AAWIDOO was a response to the Thomas–Hill controversy that inserted a gender analysis and sharply criticized Thomas. We collected 1,600 names of Black women signatories, raised tens of thousands of dollars (before crowdsourcing or even the Internet) and placed paid full-page ads in major newspapers, including the *New York Times*, in order to ensure our voices were heard. We were emboldened to take that action by the example set by our Combahee sisters.

Moreover, in 1991, after AAWIDOO's ad campaign was launched, Barbara Smith stepped forward and said, “This is a historic moment and struggle. We're going to do a poster.” Kitchen Table Press, which she had founded, designed and printed a poster that included the statement that we had written, with red, black, and green border, and listing the sixteen hundred and five names of people who had contributed to that ad. So that was a beautiful moment.

These are examples of continuities but also examples of the moments of struggle where campaigns and organizations intersect. Barbara Smith and I worked together again during the Black Radical Congress [from] 1996 to '98. Black Radical Congress was a major convening here in Chicago that was over two years in the planning. It included two thousand radical Black

organizers, scholars, and artists. And as Barbara Smith said at the time, it was the first time that Black feminism was included as a legitimate plank of a larger multifaceted Black radical tradition. In other words, revolutionary nationalists, socialists, and communists were included historically. They all represented very male-centered discourses around revolution and struggle. However, radical Black feminism, in the tradition of the Combahee River Collective, had simply not been included as a part of a Black radical tradition. And in 1998 it was.

The authors of the Combahee River Collective Statement have reminded us over and over again that this was a left document. It was a socialist document. It offered a platform that had enormous depth and breadth. And so this offers us a window into understanding the role of radical Black feminism, which is really a road map for liberation. In many Black feminist circles, CRC statement is seen as sacred text, and I say that as a pretty committed secularist.

The statement and the practice that surrounded it debunks the notion that so-called identity politics represents a narrowing rather than a broadening of our collective political vision. The document is antiracist, anticapitalist, anti-imperialist, and anti-hetero-patriarchy. That is CRC's Black feminist agenda.

There are five critical principles we can draw from the statement. One is that it is materialist. People talk about, where did their politics come from? It came from the lived experiences of Black women: of poor and working-class Black women. Not all Black women, but some of the most oppressed sectors of our communities. So Michelle Obama, Oprah Winfrey, and Beyoncé live a little bit of a different life. They don't embody the common experience of the majority of Black women. So, we can never talk about any group as a monolith.

The other principle that I take away from the work of the CRC is the one of self-determination. They insisted this: "If we don't love ourselves, if we don't work for our own liberation, who will do that?" That is the principle of self-determination. And they were explicitly anticapitalist and pro-socialist: unapologetically so. Here is a direct quote, "We recognize that the liberation of all oppressed people necessitates the destruction of the political-economic systems of capitalism and imperialism, as well as

patriarchy.” There was no ambivalence, no confusion about where they stood.

The CRC statement embodied intersectionality before “intersectionality” was a coined term. They were dealing with the intimate relationship between the variables of race, class, as well as sex, describing them as “simultaneous factors in our oppression while at the same time rejecting any form of biological determinism.” That is a very important and sophisticated concept in terms of how we wage class struggle. Their understanding of the role of patriarchy and white supremacy is clear. Finally, their work embodied radically democratic practices. The last page of the document reads: “We believe in collective process and a nonhierarchical distribution of power within our own group and in our vision of a revolutionary society.” That expression was very important. I write about Ella Baker’s principles of nonhierarchical leadership. That is embedded and embodied in the Combahee River Collective Statement.

So, CRC is an important legacy. However, the question, where do we look for radical Black feminist leadership today, remains. The Black Lives Matter movement, and Movement for Black Lives, writ large, and inclusive of many organizations and coalitions, is where the contemporary Black freedom movement has landed in many ways. And this movement—not without problems or contradictions, but on the whole—has embraced a radical Black feminist praxis as its ideological bedrock. And that is pivotal to recognize. Because then we see, from the protests in the streets of Hamburg and London, the politics of intersectionality. In the expanded sanctuary and reparations movements, in the Resist Reimagine Rebuild coalition in Chicago, we see the politics of the Combahee River Collective. In the protests of resistance, when the cop who murdered Philando Castile was let off, we see an intersectional analysis. If you listen to the speeches that people are making and the connections that groups like Black Youth Project 100 and others are making between race, class, and state violence, you see a Combahee analysis. BYP100 in particular insists that its work against economic injustice and police violence is being deployed through a “queer Black feminist lens.” When you see Black feminist delegations led by groups like Florida’s Dream Defenders, we see the internationalism of the Combahee River Collective has carried over to this generation of Black activists.

All of the work going on in the spirit of Combahee has also not been easy. We see a steady and growing backlash against the current Black freedom movement just as the Combahee River Collective experienced this in its own time. People may have seen the recent *Buzzfeed* article that really focused a laser beam attack against the Black feminist leaders of the Black Lives Matter movement. That is not to suggest that people can't be critical or that the movement shouldn't be self-critical. But that article in particular was selective in its harsh and biased attack on the women leaders of the movement. Similarly, in the *New York Times*, about a week ago [June 27, 2017], a response to the pro-Palestinian stance of the Chicago Dyke March completely denigrated the very concept of intersectionality, arguing that it was selective and divisive. The other read of the Dyke March's action—to not allow what they defined as a Zionist flag in the parade—was a group of activists defining solidarity as a matter of principle and not simple identity. They were not simply all women or all lesbians, they were queer women with very specific visions of what justice for all should look like, and that does not include occupation or settler colonialism. The writer, Bari Weiss, in the op-ed page of the *New York Times*, said intersectionality is the problem with the left today. That is an odd assertion to say the least.

What does that assertion even mean? It means all of the lame coalitions that are saying, "Put all of your differences on the back burner. Don't talk about race. Don't talk about gender. Don't talk about sexuality. Just talk about class." This approach led us to a false unity, because we have glossed over who we are and what privileges we enjoy, and oppression we suffer, as a result. The nexus between the power of radical Black feminism and the power of those forces who have the courage to speak out in solidarity with Palestine—together represent threats to a neoliberal frame and worldview. Fortunately, groups like the Jewish Voice for Peace, who stand resolutely with the cause of Palestinian freedom, have offered an alternative view to the dominant one. They have, along with our Palestinian comrades, been very courageous and very outspoken in that regard.

Let me just say three things in closing. If we take to heart the spirit and politics of the Combahee River Collective Statement, what we go away with is this: (1) never be afraid to speak truth to power, and (2) in the face

of racist, misogynist threats of violence and attacks, when you have the impulse to either fight or flight, what do you do? Fight! And, (3) always ally yourself with those on the bottom, on the margins, and at the periphery of the centers of power. And in doing so, you will land yourself at the very center of some of the most important struggles of our society and our history.

The final thought I will share is this.

The larger-than-life Cuban revolutionary Che Guevara once said, “Every revolutionary is motivated by great feelings of love.” And we have to take from that, never hesitate to love your people, and the people who struggle alongside you, but also never be afraid to critique and struggle with those you love.

CONTRIBUTOR BIOGRAPHIES



Keeanga-Yamahтта Taylor is author of *From #BlackLivesMatter to Black Liberation*, published by Haymarket Books in January 2016. The book surveys the historical and contemporary ravages of racism and persistent structural inequality, including mass incarceration, housing discrimination, police violence, and unemployment. Taylor is the recipient of the 2016 Cultural Freedom Especially Notable Book Award from the Lannan Foundation.

Taylor's interests are broadly in the fields of race and public policy, Black politics, and racial inequality in the United States. Her writing has been published in *Souls: A Critical Journal of Black Politics, Culture and Society*, *The Guardian*, *Los Angeles Times*, *Boston Review*, *New Republic*, *Al Jazeera America*, *Jacobin*, *In These Times*, *New Politics*, *The International Socialist Review*, and other publications. She is currently writing a book titled *Race for Profit: Black Housing and the Urban Crisis in the 1970s*, under contract with the University of North Carolina Press in their Justice, Power, and Politics series. Taylor received her PhD in African American studies at Northwestern University in 2013 and is currently assistant professor of African American studies at Princeton University.



Barbara Smith is an author, activist, and independent scholar who has played a groundbreaking role in opening up a national dialogue about the intersections of race, class, sexuality, and gender. She is coeditor of *Conditions: Five, The Black Women's Issue* (1979); *All the Women Are White, All the Blacks Are Men, But Some of Us Are Brave: Black Women's Studies* (1982); and *The Reader's Companion to U. S. Women's History* (1998). She is editor of *Home Girls: A Black Feminist Anthology* (1983). Smith coauthored *Yours in Struggle: Three Feminist Perspectives on Anti-Semitism and Racism* (1984). Her essays, *The Truth That Never Hurts: Writings on Race, Gender, and Freedom*, were published in 1998. *Ain't Gonna Let Nobody Turn Me Around: Forty Years of Movement Building with Barbara Smith*, edited by Alethia Jones and Virginia Eubanks, was published in 2014. She was cofounder and publisher of Kitchen Table: Women of Color Press. In 2005 she was elected to the Albany, New York, Common Council and served two terms (2006–2013).

Beverly Smith worked in public and community health in the Boston area after completing her master of public health degree at Yale University. Her commitment to the health and well-being of Black women has been a focus of her professional life and her political activism. Her passion for justice, including the fundamental right to education, led her to enroll in the doctoral program in human development and psychology at the Harvard University Graduate School of Education, from which she received a master's degree. She has been active in the Unitarian Universalist denomination for over twenty-five years and is a member of

First Parish Watertown (Massachusetts). She continues her lifelong interests in quilting, embroidery, writing, growing flowers, and studying history. Reflecting on the courses she's taken in biology, chemistry, physics, epidemiology, and math, including two years of statistics, she now thinks of herself as a science nerd.



Demita Frazier, JD, is an unrepentant lifelong Black feminist, social justice activist, thought leader, writer, and teacher. A founding member of the Combahee River Collective, she has worked, in coalition with many, on the issues of reproductive rights, domestic violence, the care and protection of endangered children, urban sustainability issues affecting food access in poor and working-class communities, and a host of other important issues affecting communities of color. She has been a consistent advocate for the unequivocal freedom of Black women so that we can get on with the urgent business of freeing the world.

A 1986 graduate of Northeastern University School of Law, Frazier brought a Black feminist perspective to her work on environmental justice issues while working for the Office of Regional Counsel, the Environmental Protection Agency, as the Region 1 representative to the Federal Women's Commission.

Her current life goals include avid participation in the ongoing project of the dismantling of the myth of white supremacy, ending misogynoir and heteropatriarchal hegemony, and undermining late stage capitalism, with the hope of joining with others in creating a democratic socialist society. A practicing unallied Buddhist, she is committed to practicing loving

kindness as she walks through life. A passionate cook and gardener, she would feed the world if she could.



Alicia Garza is an organizer, writer, and freedom dreamer living and working in Oakland, CA. She is the special projects director for the National Domestic Workers Alliance, the nation's leading voice for dignity and fairness for the millions of domestic workers in the United States, most of whom are women. She is also the co-creator of #BlackLivesMatter, a national organizing project focused on combating anti-Black state-sanctioned violence. She has been the recipient of numerous awards, including the 2016 *Root* 100 list of African American achievers and influencers between the ages of twenty-five and forty-five, 2016 *Glamour* Women of the Year Award, and the 2016 *Marie Claire* New Guard Award, and was featured in the *Politico* 50 guide to the thinkers, doers, and visionaries transforming American politics in 2015.



Barbara Ransby is an historian, writer, and longtime activist. She is a Distinguished Professor of African American studies, gender and women's studies, and history at the University of Illinois at Chicago (UIC), where

she directs the campus-wide Social Justice Initiative. Ransby is author of the award-winning biography *Ella Baker and the Black Freedom Movement: A Radical Democratic Vision*. Her most recent book is *Eslanda: The Large and Unconventional Life of Mrs. Paul Robeson* (Yale University Press, January 2013). Ransby has also published in numerous scholarly and popular publications and lectures widely. In terms of her activism, Ransby was an initiator of the *African American Women in Defense of Ourselves* campaign in 1991, a co-convenor of the Black Radical Congress in 1998, and a founder of Ella's Daughters, a network of women working in Ella Baker's tradition. In 2012 she became the second editor in chief of *SOULS*, a critical journal of Black politics, culture, and society published quarterly. In 2016, Barbara was elected president of the National Women's Studies Association (NWSA).

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I wish to thank my wife and partner, Lauren Flee, and our toddler, Ellison, for their enduring patience, love, and solidarity.

Finally, this book is dedicated to my mother, Doris Jeanne Merritt Taylor. Through the process of making this book I came to understand more about my mother's all-too-short life. A working-class Black woman from Nashville, Tennessee, she embodied the "interlocking oppressions" at the heart of the Combahee analysis. As is the case with millions of Black women in this country, the stresses and strains of that history, overlaid with the responsibilities of being a single mother, are the toxic brew of premature death. Let us end the economic system that devours the people we love.